

# Hermes Agent — Installation Guide

## Hermes Agent — Installation Guide (Blank Skeleton)

**Hardware:** Alienware 17 (any model)

**OS:** Linux Mint 22.3 on External USB SSD

**Date:** July 4, 2026

**Version:** 1.0 — Empty skeleton, no personal data

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### 0. Never Used Linux Before? Read This First (2 minutes)

It's normal to feel intimidated. But think of Linux as Windows with a slightly different look. Here's everything you need to follow this guide:

#### What's a “terminal”?

It's a black window where you type commands instead of clicking. The equivalent of Command Prompt (cmd) in Windows, just much more powerful.

**How to open it:** - Click the black icon in the bottom bar (looks like a small computer screen) - Or press `Ctrl+Alt+T` - A window appears with a cursor waiting for you to type

#### How it works in this guide:

When you see a block like this:

```
lsblk
```

It means: **type `lsblk` in the terminal and press Enter**. That's it. You don't need to understand what the command does — just type exactly what you see and press Enter.

**Rule #1:** Don't type `$` or `#` — those are just visual markers in tutorials. Type only the text after them.

**Rule #2:** If the terminal asks for your password — type it and press Enter. You won't see asterisks (`***`) as you type. This is normal — it's how Linux hides passwords. Type and press Enter with confidence.

## What is “sudo”?

`sudo` = “do this as administrator”. It's like right-click → “Run as administrator” in Windows. When a command starts with `sudo`, the terminal will ask for your password. Type your user password and press Enter.

## Copying commands (copy/paste)

All code blocks in this guide can be copied directly into the terminal: 1. Select the text from the tutorial 2. `Ctrl+C` (copy) 3. Go to the terminal 4. `Ctrl+Shift+V` (paste) — **NOT `Ctrl+V`**, that doesn't work in the terminal 5. Press Enter

## Where do files go?

| Folder                       | Windows Equivalent                        | What it contains                     |
|------------------------------|-------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|
| <code>/home/yourname/</code> | <code>C:\Users\yourname\</code>           | Your documents and files             |
| <code>~/</code>              | shortcut for <code>/home/yourname/</code> | Same thing, just shorter to type     |
| <code>/</code>               | <code>C:\</code>                          | System root (don't mess around here) |

## When something goes wrong

Don't panic. 99% of the time, the solution is to copy the error into Google. The Linux community is massive and someone has had the exact same problem before you.

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## 1. Linux Mint on External SSD + Alienware 17 Boot Select

### 1.1 What You Need

- External SSD (min 250GB) connected via USB 3.0 or USB-C
- USB stick 8GB+ for installation
- Alienware 17 laptop

### 1.2 Create the Installation USB

#### Method 1: Rufus (Windows) — RECOMMENDED

The easiest way to make a bootable USB stick is with Rufus on Windows:

1. **Download Rufus** from <https://rufus.ie> (portable .exe, ~1.4MB, no installation needed)
2. **Download Linux Mint 22.3 ISO** from <https://linuxmint.com/download.php> (choose Xfce Edition, 64-bit)
3. **Plug in the USB stick** (min 8GB) to your computer
4. **Launch Rufus** (double-click rufus.exe)
5. **Configure:**
  - **Device:** Select your USB stick from the dropdown
  - **Boot selection:** Click “SELECT” → choose the Linux Mint ISO file
  - **Partition scheme:** GPT (mandatory for UEFI)
  - **Target system:** UEFI (non CSM)
  - **File system:** FAT32 (default)
  - Leave the rest as default
6. **Click START**
7. A popup appears: “ISOHybrid image detected” — choose “**Write in ISO Image mode (Recommended)**” → OK
8. **Warning:** Rufus will erase everything on the stick. Confirm.
9. Wait 3-5 minutes until “READY” appears (green bar)

10. **Remove the stick** — it's ready to boot

## Method 2: Linux Terminal (alternative)

If you're already on Linux:

```
# Download the ISO
wget https://mirrors.edge.kernel.org/linuxmint/stable/22.3/
    linuxmint-22.3-xfce-64bit.iso

# Identify your USB stick (e.g., /dev/sdb)
lsblk

# Write the ISO to the stick (WARNING: replace /dev/sdX with your
    actual stick!)
sudo dd if=linuxmint-22.3-xfce-64bit.iso of=/dev/sdX bs=4M
    status=progress conv=fsync
sync
```

## 1.3 Configure Alienware BIOS

1. Restart the laptop, press **F2** at boot for BIOS
2. **Secure Boot** → Disabled
3. **Boot Mode** → UEFI
4. **Boot List Option** → UEFI
5. Save and exit (F10)

## 1.4 Boot from USB

1. Connect the USB stick + external SSD
2. Restart, press **F12** for boot menu
3. Select the USB stick (appears as “UEFI: ”)
4. Choose “Start Linux Mint” from the menu

## 1.5 Installing on the External SSD

### BEFORE INSTALLING: Identify the Correct Drive!

This is the most important step. If you pick the wrong one, you'll wipe Windows and all your data.

From the Linux Mint live desktop, **open a terminal** (black icon in the bottom bar) and run:

```
lsblk -o NAME,SIZE,TYPE,MOUNTPOINT,MODEL
```

You'll see something like:

```
NAME      SIZE TYPE  MOUNTPOINT  MODEL
sda       931.5G disk
├─sda1    500M part  /boot/efi
├─sda2    930G part
sdb       476.9G disk          Samsung_T5
sdc       14.8G disk          SanDisk_Ultra  ← USB stick
├─sdc1    14.8G part  /cdrom          ← (has /cdrom =
it's the live stick)
```

### How to read this:

| What you're looking at    | How to recognize it                                                                             |
|---------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Internal HDD (sda)</b> | ~1TB, model "WDC", "Seagate", "Toshiba", "HGST" — <b>DO NOT touch it</b>                        |
| <b>External SSD (sdb)</b> | Your SSD size (e.g., 500GB / 1TB), model "Samsung", "Crucial", "Kingston" — <b>install here</b> |
| <b>USB Stick (sdc)</b>    | ~8-16GB, has /cdrom as mountpoint — this is the live environment, don't install on this         |

**Golden rule:** The size and model tell you exactly which one is the external SSD. Write its name down (e.g., /dev/sdb). If you're not 100% sure, **stop** and ask someone.

### Installation Steps

1. On the desktop, double-click **Install Linux Mint**
2. Choose language → Continue
3. Keyboard layout → Continue
4. **Install multimedia codecs** → Check → Continue
5. **Installation type** → Choose **Something else** → Continue
6. In the drive list that appears:
  - Look for the drive with **the same size** you noted from `lsblk` (e.g., 477GB ≈ Samsung T5 500GB)
  - **DO NOT select** the ~1TB drive (that's the internal HDD with Windows)

- If you see multiple drives and you're unsure: **Cancel**, go back to the terminal, run `lsblk` again

7. **Delete all partitions on the external SSD** (if any exist) → select each one and press -

8. **Create partitions on the external SSD:**

| # | Size     | Use as                      | Mount point |
|---|----------|-----------------------------|-------------|
| 1 | 512 MB   | EFI System Partition        | (automatic) |
| 2 | 100 GB   | Ext4 journaling file system | /           |
| 3 | The rest | Ext4 journaling file system | /home       |

1. **Device for boot loader installation:** Choose the **external SSD** (e.g., `/dev/sdb`), NOT `/dev/sda`
2. Press **Install Now** → Continue
3. Select timezone → set user + password → Continue
4. Wait for it to finish. When “Installation Complete” appears:
  - **DO NOT click Restart Now**
  - Choose **Continue Testing**
  - From the menu → Shut Down

## 1.6 Boot from the External SSD

1. Remove the USB stick. Keep the SSD connected.
2. Turn on the laptop, press **F12** for boot menu
3. You should now see the external SSD in the list. Select it.
4. Linux Mint boots from the external SSD.

**Note:** If you want the external SSD to be the default boot only when connected, enter BIOS (F2) and move “UEFI: ” to the top of the boot order. When you unplug the SSD, the laptop will boot from the internal HDD automatically.

## 1.7 First Steps After Installation

*# System update*

```
sudo apt update && sudo apt upgrade -y
```

*# Basic packages*

```
sudo apt install -y curl wget git build-essential python3-pip
python3-venv
```

*# Node.js 22 (required for Hermes)*

```
curl -fsSL https://deb.nodesource.com/setup_22.x | sudo -E bash -
```

```
sudo apt install -y nodejs
```

```
# Verify
```

```
node --version # v22.x
```

```
python3 --version # 3.11+
```

---

## 2. Installing Hermes Agent

### 2.1 Installation

```
# Clone Hermes
```

```
cd ~
```

```
git clone https://github.com/nousresearch/hermes-agent.git  
~/.hermes/hermes-agent
```

```
# Create virtualenv
```

```
python3 -m venv ~/.hermes/hermes-agent/venv
```

```
source ~/.hermes/hermes-agent/venv/bin/activate
```

```
# Install
```

```
pip install -e ~/.hermes/hermes-agent
```

```
# Add to PATH
```

```
echo 'export PATH="$HOME/.hermes/hermes-agent/venv/bin:$PATH"' >>  
~/.bashrc
```

```
source ~/.bashrc
```

### 2.2 Verify

```
hermes --version
```

```
# Output: hermes-agent 0.16.0 (or newer)
```

### 2.3 Initialize Config

```
hermes config init
```

This creates ~/.hermes/config.yaml with default values.

---

## 3. DeepSeek API — Getting a Key + Configuring Hermes

### 3.1 Get an API Key

1. Go to <https://platform.deepseek.com>
2. Create an account (email + password)
3. Dashboard → **API Keys** → **Create new key**
4. Copy the key (starts with sk-...)
5. **Add credit** (minimum \$5) — DeepSeek is pay-as-you-go, very cheap

### 3.2 Configure Hermes to Use DeepSeek

Create the environment file:

```
nano ~/.hermes/.env
```

Add:

```
DEEPSEEK_API_KEY=sk-xxx...xxx
```

Save and secure:

```
chmod 600 ~/.hermes/.env
echo 'source ~/.hermes/.env' >> ~/.bashrc
source ~/.bashrc
```

### 3.3 Edit config.yaml

```
nano ~/.hermes/config.yaml
```

Delete everything and put:

```
model:
  default: deepseek-chat
  provider: anthropic
  base_url: https://api.deepseek.com/anthropic

agent:
  max_turns: 60
  gateway_timeout: 1800

terminal:
  backend: local
```



**What this means:** - provider: anthropic — uses the Anthropic Messages API protocol - base\_url: https://api.deepseek.com/anthropic — routed to DeepSeek - default: deepseek-chat — DeepSeek V3 model

**Available models on DeepSeek:** - deepseek-chat — DeepSeek V3 (fast, cheap, recommended) - deepseek-reasoner — DeepSeek R1 (advanced reasoning, slower)

### 3.4 Test It

```
hermes run "Hi! Tell me your name and what model you are in 2 words."
```

If it responds → DeepSeek is configured correctly.

---

## 4. Personality Customization + Journaling from Scratch

### 4.1 Directory Structure

```
mkdir -p ~/hermes-data/{personality,journal,memory}
```

### 4.2 Define a Personality (minimal template)

Create ~/hermes-data/personality/assistant.md:

```
# Personal Assistant – Definition

## Who you are
You are a personal AI assistant, loyal and direct. Your name is
[pick a name].

## How you communicate
- Language: [your language]
- Tone: direct, warm, concise
- No markdown on WhatsApp

## What you know about the user
- Name: [your name]
- Location: [city, country]
- Interests: [list 3-5]

## Rules
1. Do not disclose personal information
```

2. Do not make up answers – say when you don't know
3. Keep the conversation productive

### 4.3 Conversation Journaling (simple, local)

Create the logging script:

```
cat > ~/hermes-data/journal/log_conversation.py << 'PYEOF'
#!/usr/bin/env python3
"""
Hermes conversation journal.
Saves each session as a Markdown file.
Run manually or via cron after each session.
"""

import os
from datetime import datetime

JOURNAL_DIR = os.path.expanduser("~/hermes-data/journal")

def create_entry(date_str=None, topic="Conversation", summary=""):
    if date_str is None:
        date_str = datetime.now().strftime("%Y-%m-%d")

    filename = f"{date_str}-{topic.lower().replace(' ', '-')[:50]}.md"
    filepath = os.path.join(JOURNAL_DIR, filename)

    content = f"""# {topic}
**Date:** {datetime.now().strftime("%d %B %Y, %H:%M")}

## Summary
{summary}

## Notes
-
"""

    with open(filepath, "w") as f:
        f.write(content)

    print(f"Journal created: {filepath}")

if __name__ == "__main__":
    create_entry(
        topic=input("Topic: "),
        summary=input("Summary (1 sentence): ")
    )
PYEOF

chmod +x ~/hermes-data/journal/log_conversation.py
```

## 4.4 Cron Job for Daily Journal (optional)

```
# Start Hermes and configure a cron job
hermes cron create \
  --name "Daily Journal" \
  --schedule "0 22 * * *" \
  --prompt "Generate a summary of today: what was discussed,
           decisions made, tasks for tomorrow. Save to ~/hermes-data/
           journal/YYYY-MM-DD-summary.md" \
  --deliver "local"
```

## 4.5 Inject Personality Into Every Hermes Session

In `~/.hermes/config.yaml`, add under `agent::`

```
agent:
  max_turns: 60
  environment_hint: |
    Personality defined in ~/hermes-data/personality/assistant.md
    Journal in ~/hermes-data/journal/
    Memory in ~/hermes-data/memory/
```

Alternatively, you can use Hermes' **Memory** feature directly in conversation:

You: "My name is [X], I live in [Y], and I like [Z]. Remember this."  
Hermes: saves it automatically to persistent memory.

---

## APPENDIX A: Useful Hermes Commands

```
# Start gateway (WhatsApp, Telegram, etc.)
hermes gateway start
```

```
# List cron jobs
hermes cron list
```

```
# View current config
hermes config show
```

```
# List learned skills
hermes skills list
```

```
# View saved memory
cat ~/.hermes/memories/*.md
```

```
# Stop gateway
hermes gateway stop
```

---

## APPENDIX B: Minimal Structure After Installation

```
/home/user/
├── .hermes/
│   ├── config.yaml      ← Model + personality config
│   ├── .env             ← DEEPSEEK_API_KEY
│   └── skills/          ← Self-learned skills (initially
empty)
│   ├── memories/        ← Persistent memory
│   ├── cron/            ← Scheduled jobs
│   └── hermes-agent/    ← Installation
│       └── venv/
├── hermes-data/
│   ├── personality/
│   │   └── assistant.md  ← Assistant definition
│   ├── journal/
│   │   └── ...           ← Daily journals
│   └── memory/
│       └── ...           ← Persistent notes
```

---

### **Minimal document — empty skeleton, no personal data.**

After installation, the system is a blank Hermes. Personality, memory, and behavior develop organically through conversation.